

Center Church Turns 1

Jeff Palen · Center Church of Star, Star, ID · October 4, 2026

Psalm 127:1

PRIMARY TEXT

35 min

SERMON LENGTH

6

SCRIPTURE
REFERENCES

35

SECTIONS WE MAPPED

THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

The work of building the church is a privilege that brings us close to God's craftsmanship, and those who labor with the Lord experience His majesty in ways that passive observers never can.

Summary

This anniversary sermon revisits Psalm 127:1 to reframe church work not as necessity but as privilege. Pastor Jeff argues that while God alone builds His house and guards His city, He invites believers into the labor—not because He needs help, but to give them front-row access to His craftsmanship. The sermon moves through three privileges: the privilege of working with God, the privilege of seeing Him accomplish the impossible, and the privilege of enjoying what He builds. Pastor Jeff applies this to Center Church's first year, calling the congregation to active participation rather than passive attendance. He then extends the metaphor to family life, challenging husbands, wives, singles, and children to ask whether their homes serve the ultimate purpose of bringing Christ to the world. The sermon concludes with a call to deep fellowship and a vision for future generations recounting God's work in this church.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/CenterChurchStar/sermons/center-church-turns-1-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Providence / Sovereignty** — The sermon builds entirely on the paradox of divine sovereignty and human responsibility—God alone builds, yet human workers are necessary and privileged.
- **Ecclesiology** — The sermon applies Psalm 127 to the nature and building of the local church, defining God's work as saving people and calling them into sacrificial love, not organizational formation.
- **Doxology / Worship** — Pastor Jeff frames work itself as worship and proximity to God's majesty, transforming labor from duty into doxological participation in divine craftsmanship.
- **Ethics / Moral Theology** — The sermon's application extends to family roles and church fellowship, calling specific groups to concrete patterns of Christ-centered living.

Themes

The privilege of working with God

Divine sovereignty and human responsibility

Active participation vs. passive observation

Proximity to God's craftsmanship

Christ-centered family and church life

Generational witness

Editor notes

- The sermon's rhetorical architecture mirrors its content—moving from exposition of the paradox to experiential application, the structure itself enacts the shift from understanding to participation.
- The Bob Ross illustration is unexpectedly effective: it democratizes the aesthetic pleasure of watching mastery unfold, making the privilege of witnessing God's work accessible rather than abstract.
- The father's construction story functions as both bookend and hermeneutic—the opening anecdote returns in unit 16 with theological freight, showing how labor creates intimacy with structure that users never know.
- The sermon's strongest move is reframing the psalm's apparent redundancy ('unless the Lord builds... unless the Lord watches') not as poetic repetition but as invitation to reconsider work's purpose entirely.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. Why God Invites Us to Work He Doesn't Need Done

Most Christians understand that God is sovereign, but many conclude this makes human effort pointless. This article argues that God invites us into His work not because He needs our labor but because the work itself is a gift—proximity to the Master at His craft. The point isn't the house we build but who we become in the building.

FROM: UNITS 8–10: THE PRIVILEGE OF WORK AS PROXIMITY TO GOD'S CRAFTSMANSHIP

2. The Front-Row Seat You Can't Buy: What Workers See That Spectators Miss

There's a difference between living in a house and building one. This article explores how participation in God's work grants access to His majesty that passive observation never can. Using Psalm 127 and the metaphor of watching a masterpiece take shape, it challenges readers to ask what they're missing by staying on the sidelines.

FROM: UNITS 10–13: THE PRIVILEGE OF SEEING GOD OVERCOME HUMAN LIMITATIONS

3. The Paradox Every Christian Must Hold: Trust Completely, Work Fully

Psalm 127:1 presents a theological puzzle: if God builds the house, why do we labor? This article examines how Scripture holds divine sovereignty and human responsibility in tension without collapsing either side, and what it looks like to live in that tension daily without reducing faith to passivity or work to self-reliance.

FROM: UNITS 6–7: THE SIMULTANEOUS CALL TO TRUST AND TO ACT

4. God's Building Project Isn't What You Think

When Scripture talks about God building His house, most readers picture organizational growth or facility expansion. This article corrects that assumption, arguing that God's building work is the calling and formation of people who love one another sacrificially because Christ first loved them. Programs and structures matter only as they serve this deeper work.

FROM: UNITS 18–19: GOD'S BUILDING WORK AS RELATIONAL FORMATION, NOT ORGANIZATIONAL DEVELOPMENT

5. What Your Children Will Remember When They Drive Past Your Church

Psalm 127 connects house-building to heritage and children. This article challenges parents and church members to consider what legacy they're leaving: Will the next generation remember a building, or will they recount God's transforming work in real people? It calls readers to labor in ways that create stories worth telling.

FROM: UNITS 26–27, 32, 34: THE GENERATIONAL PURPOSE OF GOD'S BUILDING WORK

6. Is Your Family Serving the Same Purpose as David's House?

The ultimate purpose of God building David's house was to bring Christ into the world. This article applies that lens to Christian families today, asking whether our households exist for comfort and legacy or to make Christ known. It challenges both married and single Christians to align their domestic lives with God's redemptive purposes.

FROM: UNITS 27–31: THE CHRISTOLOGICAL PURPOSE OF HOUSEHOLD BUILDING

7. Why Passive Church Attendance Is a Tragedy, Not a Victory

Many Christians consider regular attendance a spiritual win. This article argues that showing up without engaging is like touring a construction site without picking up a tool—you see the scaffolding but miss the wonder. Drawing on Psalm 127, it calls readers to ask why they would settle for observation when participation offers intimacy with God's work.

FROM: UNITS 22–24: THE CALL FROM PASSIVE ATTENDANCE TO ACTIVE PARTICIPATION

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

When Pastor Jeff says that God 'alone builds the house and guards the city,' what does he mean by God's exclusive agency here—and what would it look like for us to honor that truth while still actively participating in the work?

- ↳ Can you think of a specific moment this past year at Center Church where you witnessed something only God could do?

PSALM 127:1

The sermon contrasts viewing our work as mere 'necessity' versus viewing it as 'privilege.' What's the difference between these two postures, and how might that difference show up in the way we serve at church or lead our families?

Pastor Jeff claims that 'those who labor with the Lord gain front-row access to His majesty and craftsmanship that passive observers never know.' What does it actually mean to see and enjoy God's work in the moment, rather than simply receiving its benefits after the fact?

- ↳ When have you experienced that kind of intimacy with God's work—where you weren't just benefiting from something, but you were watching Him do it?

The sermon emphasizes that God's building work is not organizational formation but 'the calling of people to love one another sacrificially because Christ first loved them.' How does that reframe what we're actually building here at Center Church?

- ↳ If that's what God is building, how does it change what we should prioritize or focus on in our church life together?

MATTHEW 16:18

Many of us may feel we've already 'missed out' on the privilege of being part of Center Church's first year. What does the sermon say about whether it's too late to join God's work and experience that joy?

- ↳ What would it look like for you to step into that work in a concrete way this next season?

As we think about our families, our marriages, our singleness, or our role as children in this church—how does the gospel of Christ shape the way we build together, and what does it mean that future generations will recount God's work in this place?

Daily Readings

This week we deepen our grasp of God's exclusive agency in building His church and the privilege of laboring alongside Him, moving from foundational sovereignty to the joy that workers alone experience.

Monday [Matthew 16:18](#)

When Jesus declares, 'I will build my church,' He reveals the exclusive agency behind all spiritual formation. We do not build the church through programs, planning, or programs alone—Christ Himself is the active builder, and the gates of hell cannot prevail against His work. As we labor at Center Church, we join what Christ is already doing, not the reverse.

Tuesday [Psalm 127:1](#)

The psalmist does not say, 'If the Lord does not build, sit idle'—he calls builders and watchers into the work. Our labor is real, urgent, and necessary to our obedience, yet its fruit depends entirely on God's hand. In this paradox, we discover the deep humility and joy of co-laboring: we work with all our might while clinging to the One whose power alone accomplishes what matters eternally.

Wednesday [Matthew 16:18](#)

Christ's promise to build His church defies human capability—no human strategy, no organizational skill, no charisma creates what only the risen Lord can create. When we witness a hardened heart converted, a fractured marriage reconciled, or a stranger welcomed into the family of God, we behold what only Christ does. This is the privilege that makes our work glorious: we labor knowing we partner with the One who accomplishes the impossible.

Thursday [Psalm 127:1](#)

The house God builds is not a structure of programs, budgets, or institutional mechanics—it is a people bound together by the love of Christ. Every conversation, every act of forgiveness, every sacrifice of time or comfort for another believer is the material of God's building. As we serve one another at Center Church, we are not maintaining an organization; we are participating in the formation of a bride, a body, a temple of the Holy Spirit.

Friday [Matthew 16:18](#)

Those who labor alongside Christ do not merely inherit a safe city or finished house—they taste the joy of witnessing transformation, of seeing God's hand move in real time, of knowing intimacy with His craftsmanship that no spectator can know. As we look back on Center Church's first year and forward to what Christ will build through us, may we embrace not ease, but the incomparable privilege of working, watching, and rejoicing in what God alone can do.

Memory Verse

Unless the Lord builds the house, those who build it labor in vain. Unless the Lord guards the city, the watchman stays awake in vain.

— *Psalms 127:1*

This verse anchors the sermon's central claim that God's exclusive agency in building the church is not a reason for passivity but an invitation to joyful participation—we labor not in vain when we work **with** the Lord, experiencing His majesty and craftsmanship firsthand. Memorizing this verse captures both God's sovereign sufficiency and our privilege of partnership in His redemptive work.

Family Conversation

Working Alongside God

Pastor Jeff said that when we work **with** God to build the church, we get to see Him do impossible things up close. Can you think of a time when you saw God do something at Center Church this year—maybe someone becoming a Christian, or friends helping each other, or our church growing—that you wouldn't have believed possible if you hadn't **seen** it happen? What was it, and how did it feel different from just hearing about it?

WORKS FOR AGES 8+ — YOUNGER KIDS CAN LISTEN AND SHARE SIMPLER OBSERVATIONS; TEENS AND ADULTS CAN GO DEEPER INTO WHAT IT MEANS TO **WITNESS** GOD'S WORK VERSUS JUST BENEFITING FROM IT

For parents: This prompt invites your family to reflect on what it means to **do** something together with God rather than just receive His blessings passively. Listen for moments when your kids notice the difference between watching and participating—that's the heart of what Pastor Jeff preached about.

For Couples

Working Together With God

What did you hear in this sermon about the privilege—not the burden—of working alongside God in building His church, and how did that land in your heart?

As a couple, where are we tempted to either sit passively on the sidelines or to labor as if everything depends on us alone, and how might we invite each other into the joy of trusting and working together?

What is one way we can pray for each other this week to experience God's majesty and craftsmanship more deeply—whether in our marriage, our families, or our participation in Center Church?

Questions, or something we got wrong? Reply to this email, or use "Suggest a change" on your sermon page.